



grasping hand with
semi opposable thumb

Western gorilla

Gorilla gorilla

In the past, gorillas were often portrayed as brutish and dangerous, a reputation not helped by the early King Kong films, but they are, in fact, highly intelligent, peaceful, and almost entirely vegetarian. Western gorillas live in lowland forests and swamps in Central Africa and feed mainly on ripe fruit, along with some plant shoots and leaves. Their grinding teeth and massive jaw muscles are adapted for chewing vegetation. The only animals they eat are ants and termites.

Nonaggressive displays

Although the western gorilla is the heaviest and most powerfully built of all the great apes, the huge mature males rely on ritual displays rather than aggression to assert their dominance. They take 18 years to reach their full size and are known as silverbacks after the pale patches of fur on their backs. Adult females are only around half the size.

A typical gorilla family group consists of a single silverback and up to 12 adult females and their offspring of various ages. The bonds between the family members are very strong, and many group members stay together for life.

Western gorillas are threatened by deforestation, illegal poaching for the bushmeat trade, and some human diseases such as the ebola virus, which affects apes as well as humans.



△ DEPENDENT YOUNG

Young gorillas depend on their mothers for three to five years, suckling throughout. This is one of the longest nursing periods of any mammal.



△ RITUAL DISPLAY

Dominant male gorillas advertise their status by standing upright, baring their long canine teeth, thrashing vegetation, and beating their broad chests with their hands.

◁ ON THE MOVE

Gorillas travel mainly on foot, covering an average of 1 mile (2 km) a day in search of food. The young ride piggyback on their mothers, or cling to their undersides.